

Comments of the Auditing Standards Committee of the Auditing Section of the American Accounting Association on the SEC's Semiannual Reporting Proposal

Participating Committee Members

Dereck Barr-Pulliam
University of Louisville
College of Business
School of Accountancy

Sean A. Dennis
University of Central Florida
College of Business
Kenneth G. Dixon School of Accountancy

Travis P. Holt
Auburn University
Harbert College of Business
School of Accountancy

John D. Keyser (Committee Chair)
Arizona State University
W.P. Carey School of Business
School of Accountancy

Michelle McAllister
Northern Arizona University
The W.A. Franke College of Business
Department of Economics, Finance, and Accounting

Aleksandra B. Zimmerman
Florida State University
Herbert Wertheim College of Business
Department of Accounting

Note: The views expressed in this letter are those of the participating members of the Committee and do not reflect an official position of the American Accounting Association. The comments do not necessarily reflect the views of every member.

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SUMMARY: On May 5, 2026, the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) issued a request for comment on its proposal to allow its registrants the option to reduce the frequency of interim reporting from quarterly to semiannually (SEC 2026). This comment letter summarizes the views of the participating members of the Auditing Standards Committee of the Auditing Section of the American Accounting Association. We raise concerns about the proposal to provide issuers with the option to reduce the frequency of financial reporting from quarterly to semiannually.

Generative AI technology has not been used in the preparation of this manuscript.

I. INTRODUCTION

In May 2026, the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC or the Commission) issued a proposal to provide registrants with the option to file their interim financial information semiannually rather than quarterly (SEC 2026). We appreciate the opportunity to provide feedback on this proposal. This comment letter summarizes the participating committee members' observations related to the proposal. Overall, we have concerns that the proposal could be harmful to investors, particularly retail investors who rely on SEC filings to obtain information used for decisions to buy, hold, or sell securities.

II. OVERALL OBSERVATIONS

Quarterly Reporting is Useful to Investors

Prior accounting research suggests that investors find quarterly financial statement information decision-useful, as evidenced by the strong market reaction to quarterly earnings announcements (Landsman and Maydew 2002). In fact, market reactions to quarterly earnings announcements have increased over time, particularly in the post-SOX era (Beaver, McNichols, and Wang 2018). This research suggests that investors place greater value on quarterly financial information today than in prior decades.

Quarterly earnings announcements also elicit a stronger market reaction than other firm news events, indicating that financial statement users view these disclosures as an important source of information about firm performance (Beaver et al. 2018). A likely explanation for this difference is that quarterly earnings announcements are accompanied by auditor-reviewed financial statements, increasing the perceived reliability of the disclosure relative to other firm communications (Schroeder 2016). Moreover, improvements in financial reporting quality and internal controls following the SOX legislation may have strengthened investor confidence in quarterly financial information, increasing its usefulness to capital markets.

Timeliness of Financial Information Impacts its Usefulness

The Financial Accounting Standards Board (FASB) Conceptual Framework suggests that the proposed change could diminish the usefulness of financial information:

Timeliness means having information available to decision makers in time to be capable of influencing their decisions. Generally, the older the information is, the less useful it is. (FASB 2024, 44).

Information that is provided semiannually is less timely than information provided quarterly. Generally accepted accounting principles recognize the importance of interim financial reporting in providing users with timely information regarding changes in a firm's financial position and operating results between annual reporting periods. According to ASC 270-10-45-1, "Interim financial information is essential to provide investors and others with timely information as to the progress of the entity" (FASB 2026).

Comparability and Consistency of Financial Information Impact its Usefulness

The FASB's conceptual framework emphasizes the importance of comparability as an enhancing qualitative characteristic of accounting information:

Users' decisions involve choosing between alternatives, for example, selling or holding an investment, or investing in one reporting entity or another.

Consequently, information about a reporting entity is more useful if it can be compared with similar information about other entities and with similar information about the same entity for another period or another date (FASB 2024, 43).

The proposal could impair both intertemporal (within-firm) and cross-sectional (across-firms) comparability. In addition, the proposal's annual election mechanism may reduce consistency in reporting practices over time. Under the proposed framework, a firm could report quarterly in one year, elect semiannual reporting in the next, and subsequently return to quarterly reporting in a later period. Collectively, reductions in timeliness, comparability, and consistency may make it more difficult for financial statement users to evaluate performance trends, benchmark firms against peers, and interpret changes in reported results, thereby reducing the decision-usefulness of financial information.

Potential Adverse Impacts on Investors and Investees

While quarterly reporting imposes regulatory costs on firms, reducing reporting frequency could place investors at a disadvantage by providing fewer timely updates on firm performance, increasing information asymmetry and uncertainty. This reduction in the availability and reliability of information may contribute to greater market volatility, reduced liquidity, and a higher cost of capital as investors demand additional compensation for bearing increased risk. In addition, quarterly earnings releases without reviewed financial statements may be viewed as less reliable, potentially reducing investor confidence in the disclosed information. Accordingly, any proposal to reduce reporting frequency should be evaluated not only in the context of the loss of information timeliness but also in the context of the potential loss of information credibility associated with reviewed interim financial statements. Collectively, less frequent information could decrease its decision usefulness.

The proposal may also create unintended signaling effects in capital markets. Although it is ultimately an empirical question which firms would elect to report semiannually, investors may interpret reporting frequency as a signal of firm quality, transparency, or governance. This concern is consistent with prior research showing that corporate disclosure reduces information asymmetry between managers and outside investors and plays an important role in capital-market functioning (Healy and Palepu 2001). For example, larger firms may continue to report quarterly, while smaller firms disproportionately elect semiannual reporting. Over time, quarterly reporting could become a de facto best practice, causing investors to view firms that elect semiannual reporting less favorably, regardless of their underlying economic performance. Such signaling effects could harm investors by introducing new uncertainty into the market – and may, at the same time, harm firms seeking to raise additional capital. Relatedly, prior research finds that more frequent financial reporting is associated with lower information asymmetry and a lower cost of equity capital (e.g., Fu, Kraft, and Zhang 2012).

Beyond these concerns, the proposed rule may also reduce the availability of standardized, machine-readable financial information. Although many firms may continue to issue quarterly earnings releases, a shift away from quarterly SEC filings could substantially reduce the amount of XBRL-tagged financial data available to investors and other market participants. Unlike SEC filings, earnings releases are not subject to the same level of standardization, making them more difficult to aggregate, compare, and analyze across firms. The loss of XBRL-tagged quarterly information may increase information-processing costs for investors, analysts, researchers, and automated trading systems while reducing the accessibility and comparability of financial information. Consequently, the proposal may impose unintended costs on financial statement users even if it reduces reporting costs for certain firms.

Structural Costs, Constraints, and Market Frictions

The proposed rule may create significant transition costs for firms that elect semiannual reporting and later return to quarterly reporting. This concern is particularly relevant because the proposal contemplates an annual election, allowing firms to change reporting frequencies from one year to the next (SEC 2026). Currently, SEC Regulation S-X requires interim financial statements included in quarterly reports on Form 10-Q to be reviewed by the auditor. The proposed changes would maintain the interim review requirement, clarifying that the interim financial statements may be “included in quarterly reports on Form 10-Q or semiannual reports on Form 10-S” (SEC 2026, 175). Since the proposed rule would not require reviews of quarterly information included in Form 8-K for issuers electing semiannual reporting, the first and third quarter financial information for companies electing semiannual reporting may not have been subject to review by the independent auditor. Consequently, if a firm subsequently returns to quarterly reporting, auditors would be required to perform additional procedures to obtain sufficient support for comparative quarterly information presented in future filings. This reporting pattern would require reconstructing and reviewing previously unreviewed quarterly information. As a result, any short-term compliance savings associated with semiannual reporting may be partially offset by substantial transition costs when firms change reporting frequencies across reporting periods.

The proposed rule change may provide fewer benefits than anticipated because a significant portion of firms may be functionally unable to implement semiannual reporting due to existing regulatory, contractual, or governance requirements. For example, many financial institutions and insurance companies are already subject to separate quarterly regulatory reporting requirements. In addition, many private debt agreements and lending arrangements

require borrowers to provide creditors with quarterly financial information. Firms may also continue preparing quarterly financial information to satisfy the information needs of boards of directors, audit committees, investors, and other stakeholders. As a result, many firms may be required to continue preparing quarterly financial information regardless of SEC reporting requirements, thereby limiting the proposal's anticipated cost savings.

Potential Audit Consequences

Quarterly reviews provide recurring auditor involvement that may facilitate the earlier identification and resolution of accounting issues before they affect annual financial statements. This role is consistent with PCAOB interim review standards, which describe interim reviews as involving analytical procedures and inquiries of financial and accounting personnel and requiring auditors to update their knowledge of the company's business and internal control as they relate to interim financial reporting (PCAOB AS 4105). Because reviews occur throughout the year, they create multiple opportunities for auditors to identify accounting errors, challenge management estimates, evaluate unusual transactions, and address emerging financial reporting issues before they become entrenched. Eliminating two review periods may increase the time during which material weaknesses go undetected, potentially increasing the costs to remediate when eventually discovered. This concern is particularly important because PCAOB standards recognize that a material weakness can exist even when the financial statements are not materially misstated and that the ICFR audit is designed to support the auditor's opinion on internal control effectiveness as of year-end (PCAOB AS 2201). In some cases, issuers may not have sufficient time to remediate material weaknesses before the reporting period ends, leading to more adverse internal control reports and opinions (and the related capital market consequences). Consistent with this concern, Barr-Pulliam, Brown-Liburd, and Sanderson (2022)

find that internal control opinions affect perceptions of audit quality, assurance, and auditor negligence, highlighting that adverse ICFR reporting outcomes, in some settings, can have consequences beyond the disclosure itself. In addition, auditors currently identify and resolve many issues during quarterly reviews before they materially affect annual financial reporting. Delays in identifying and resolving financial reporting issues may increase the magnitude of any required year-end corrections or adjustments (making these adjustments more difficult for auditors to negotiate).

Quarterly reviews also allow auditors to maintain a current understanding of client risks throughout the year. Recurring interactions with management provide opportunities to identify changes in operations, personnel, information systems, internal controls, and economic conditions that may affect the risk of financial reporting. Less frequent auditor involvement may reduce awareness of these developments and impair the timely identification of emerging accounting issues. As a result, risk assessments may become less timely, requiring auditors to modify planned procedures later in the engagement. This may reduce audit efficiency and increase audit effort as issues that could have been identified and addressed earlier are instead resolved closer to year-end.

In addition, reducing the number of quarterly reviews may not eliminate audit work; instead, it may shift a portion of that work to periods when audit firms already face significant resource constraints. Prior audit research finds that workload compression and high auditor workloads are associated with lower audit quality, including through increased pressure on audit teams and reduced capacity to perform and review audit procedures effectively (e.g., López and Peters 2012; Persellin, Schmidt, Vandervelde, and Wilkins 2019). To the extent that accounting issues, material weaknesses, or unusual transactions are identified later in the review or audit

process, auditors may require additional time to investigate and resolve those matters under tighter deadlines. Such workload compression may negatively affect audit quality and harm investors. In some cases, the additional time required to investigate and resolve issues identified later in the process could delay the issuance of audited financial statements, thereby creating other compliance costs for firms and further reducing the timeliness of financial information available to investors.

If companies continue issuing quarterly earnings releases after quarterly reviews are no longer required, the perceived reliability of those disclosures may decline as auditor involvement becomes optional. Under the proposed framework, firms may continue providing quarterly information to investors while no longer obtaining auditor reviews of the underlying financial information. This concern is consistent with evidence that preliminary earnings releases issued before audit completion are more likely to be revised, suggesting that auditor involvement can improve the reliability of earnings information released to capital markets (e.g., Bronson, Hogan, Johnson, and Ramesh 2011). Companies facing pressure to meet earnings targets may have greater discretion over unreviewed quarterly disclosures, potentially increasing uncertainty regarding the credibility of reported results. As a result, investors may place undue reliance on risky and unreviewed interim disclosures. Prior research finds that lower financial reporting frequency can increase investors' reliance on alternative sources of earnings news, which may create excessive information spillovers from peer firms (e.g., Arif and De George 2020). Over time, this could lead to investor losses, greater market volatility, and higher costs of capital for registrants.

Potential Unintended Consequences for the Audit Market

The proposal may also have unintended consequences for the audit services market. Some audit firms may view firms that elect semiannual reporting as presenting greater engagement risk (e.g., Johnstone 2000). First, electing semiannual reporting will reveal valuable information about registrants' control environment. Doing so could easily become an important risk factor for audit firms to consider in their engagement acceptance/continuance decisions, risk assessments, and pricing. Prior research finds that internal control weaknesses are associated with audit fee premiums and that audit fees may remain elevated for some firms even after material weaknesses are remediated (e.g., Hogan and Wilkins 2008; Munsif, Raghunandan, Rama, and Singhvi 2011). Additionally, auditors will inevitably interact less with management under a semiannual reporting routine, relative to a quarterly reporting regime. This will result in fewer opportunities to evaluate emerging accounting issues and identify potential financial reporting problems before year-end. As a result, certain audit firms may become less willing to serve firms that elect semiannual reporting or may require higher fees to compensate for the additional risk. To the extent this occurs, affected firms may face reduced auditor choice and potentially higher audit costs. In addition, if firms electing semiannual reporting are concentrated among a smaller subset of audit firms, the proposal could have unintended consequences for audit quality and competition within the audit market.

III. ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Critique of the Economic Analysis and Short-termism Assumptions

The Commission's economic analysis suggests a causal link between quarterly reporting and managerial short-termism and there is some evidence consistent with this view (Kajuter, Lessenich, Nienhaus, and Van Gemmern 2022). For example, Kraft, Vashishtha, and

Venkatachalam (2018) find that companies decreased investments in fixed assets after the United States increased the frequency of interim reporting to quarterly. However, there is also evidence that contradicts the view that increased reporting frequency leads to higher levels of managerial myopia. For example, Nallareddy, Pozen, and Rajgopal (2021) find that changing the frequency of reporting requirements has essentially no impact on firm investment decisions.

In its proposal, the Commission argues that “it is difficult to empirically estimate the counterfactual value of semiannual reporting” with respect to “the issue of what reporting frequency would be optimal for investors and companies” (SEC 2026, 98). However, research confirms that higher reporting frequency reduces information asymmetry and financing frictions, with higher frequency associated with a lower cost of equity capital (Fu, Kraft, and Zhang 2012). Moving to a semiannual cadence doubles the length of the inter-announcement window, leading to a broader buildup of adverse selection risk and a potentially higher net cost of equity capital.

Adverse Impact on Continuous Monitoring Framework

The Commission acknowledges in the proposal that “less frequent reporting could delay the identification and resolution” of misstatements and control deficiencies (SEC 2026, 119). Less timely involvement of the auditor in significant unusual transactions and new types of transactions will delay the detection and correction of misstatements as well as the identification and remediation of internal control deficiencies. This may lead to higher audit fees that offset any savings from eliminating reviews of the first and third quarters. For example, unremediated control deficiencies will increase the risk of material misstatement and the extent of required audit procedures necessary to address the heightened risk.

Potential Impact on Market Competition for Audit Services

The Commission notes that firm size and operating complexity are likely to affect issuers' reporting frequency decisions (SEC 2026, 122). We suspect that smaller issuers will be more likely to choose less frequent reporting. These issuers are more likely to be served by smaller audit firms. Thus, the estimated 12% reduction in audit fees resulting from this proposal may fall disproportionately on smaller audit firms and could lead to further concentration of the audit market, a systemic risk that is not currently addressed in the proposal.¹

IV. RESPONSES TO SELECTED QUESTIONS

Question 20: In connection with any adoption of the proposal, should there be a new requirement for semiannual filers that announce or release earnings for the first or third quarters of their fiscal year (i.e., the periods that would later be subsumed in Forms 10-S and 10-K but for which there would be no quarterly report filed with the Commission)—that financial information in any first or third quarter earnings releases be reviewed by an independent public accountant? If so, would any changes to current auditing standards (e.g., governing reviews) be required?

Semiannual filers that choose to announce or release quarterly earnings should be required to have their financial statements reviewed by their external auditor. At the time the Commission adopted the rule to require interim reviews, it cited the need for more discipline in the financial reporting process to address increasing concerns about inappropriate earnings management (SEC 1999). Ettredge, Simon, Smith, and Stone (2000) find that quarterly reviews result in more adjustments in the quarters and fewer adjustments at year-end. Moreover, allowing companies to choose semiannual reporting to avoid interim reviews while still reporting quarterly earnings does not seem appropriate.

¹ See page 94 of the proposal for the Commission's estimate that the reduction in fees will be approximately 12% (SEC 2026).

Paragraph .03 of PCAOB Auditing Standard (AS) 4105 refers to the SEC requirement for registrants to file quarterly reports on Form 10-Q or Form 10-QSB. In addition to revising this requirement to refer to Form 10-S, the language would also need to be revised to address circumstances where the auditor reviews interim financial statements included in an 8-K.

Question 24: Would the nature and extent of procedures that an independent public accountant performs during a review change depending upon whether the independent public accountant is performing a review over a fiscal semiannual period or a fiscal quarterly period? Would independent public accountants conducting reviews do the same amount of work for a fiscal semiannual period as they currently do for two quarterly fiscal periods on a combined basis? Would an independent public accountant experience any impact on efficiency or economies of scale when conducting reviews and annual audits under semiannual reporting versus under quarterly reporting for the same company? Would any changes to independent public accountants' review or audit procedures or any impact on efficiency or economies of scale result in changes in costs to companies? If so, describe the impact and whether the impact could vary depending upon the size of the registrant subject to the review.

Interim reviews consist primarily of inquiry and analytical procedures. However, auditors typically perform audit procedures on significant unusual transactions in the period in which those transactions occur. Reducing the number of interim reviews from three to one will adversely affect the auditor's ability to identify and perform relevant audit procedures, delaying those procedures until later in the year. Moving audit work to busier times has the potential to significantly adversely impact audit quality (Heo, Kwon, and Tan 2020; Lopez and Peters 2012).

Question 25: Would companies that elect semiannual reporting retain their independent public accountant to perform a review of their financial statements at the end of each quarter either to: (1) support financial information that is used for purposes of a quarterly earnings release (notwithstanding that, as noted above, there is no Commission requirement for a quarterly earnings release to be reviewed by an independent public accountant), or (2) guard against the possible need for a quarterly review to be performed should the company decide to change back to quarterly reporting in a future period (where that period would require comparative quarterly data for the prior year)?

We do not know whether semiannual filers would voluntarily elect to have their quarterly financial statements reviewed by their external auditors. We therefore recommend that the

Commission require semiannual filers who choose to announce or release quarterly earnings to engage their auditor to perform interim reviews prior to release.

Question 26: For semiannual filers, what impact would a shift to semiannual reporting have on: (1) companies' disclosure controls and procedures, (2) companies' internal control over financial reporting, and (3) independent public accountants' strategy and approach for the annual audit of companies' internal control over financial reporting or financial statements? With semiannual reporting, is there a potential for a material increase in the risk that material misstatements (either due to error or fraud) or control deficiencies are not timely detected by or communicated to the independent public accountant thereby limiting potential remediation of these issues by the issuer? Please provide any data related to these questions.

The shift to semiannual reporting will result in less frequent evaluation of the effectiveness of disclosure controls and internal controls over financial reporting. As a result, management and auditors may detect internal control deficiencies less timely, increasing the risk of material misstatement in interim and annual periods.

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